

Class 10th | English



Footprints Without Feet

The Midnight Visitor

LECTURE - 2

QUESTIONS

1. How is Ausable different from other secret agents?

Ans. Ausable is different from other secret agents in several ways. He was extremely fat. In spite of living in Paris for over twenty years, he spoke French and German with difficulty and had an American accent.

Instead of getting messages passed secretly to him by beautiful girls, he got only a routine telephone call for making an appointment.

QUESTIONS

2. Who is Fowler and what is his first authentic thrill of the day?

Ans. Fowler is a writer and he had come to meet Ausable in order to get some material for his writings. His first authentic thrill of the day came when he saw a man in Ausable's room pointing a pistol towards Ausable and himself.

QUESTIONS

3. How has Max got in?

Ans. Max had gotten into the room by using a pass key or master key.



QUESTIONS

4. How does Ausable say he got in?

Ans. Ausable said that Max had got into the room through the balcony.

QUESTIONS

- 5.** "Ausable did not fit any description of a secret agent Fowler had ever read." What do secret agents in books and films look like, in your opinion?

Discuss in groups or in class some stories or movies featuring spies, detectives and secret agents, and compare their appearance with that of Ausable in this story. (You may mention characters from fiction in languages other than English. In English fiction you may have come across Sherlock Holmes, Hercule Poirot, or Miss Marple. Have you watched any movies featuring James Bond?)

HW

QUESTIONS

Ans. Secret agents in fiction are projected like the ideal man, 'Tall, dark and handsome. They are usually well-built and keep beautiful women for company. They would smoke a pipe (like Sherlock Holmes) or a cigar and execute death-defying stunts (like James Bond). Movies based on James Bond show hi-tech gadgets which assist the detective in countering villains. However, there are some exceptions to this appearance of a secret agent.

A character named Feluda was created by Satyajit Ray, the famous Bengali filmmaker. Feuda was a tall athletic figure who relied on his superb analytical ability and observation skills.

(Students can discuss about more detective or secret agent figures)

QUESTIONS

6. How does Ausable manage to make Max believe that there is a balcony attached to his room? Look back at his detailed description of it. What makes it a convincing story?

Ans. Ausable creates a detailed description of how his office was part of a bigger apartment and how the next room had a direct connection with a balcony. His statement that somebody else also broke into his office through that balcony earlier made it a convincing story. In this way, Ausable managed to make Max believe that there is a balcony attached to his room. Ausable's ability to think quickly and calmly in a situation of panic makes it convincing.

QUESTIONS

7. Looking back at the story, when do you think Ausable thought up his plan for getting rid of Max? Do you think he had worked out his plan in detail right from the beginning? Or did he make up a plan taking advantage of events as they happened?

Ans. No, I don't think that he had worked out his plan in detail from the very beginning. Infact, the plan was spontaneous.

Ausable, essentially, took advantage of events as they happened

Ausable made up a story of the balcony outside the room and as there was a knock at the door, he told Max that it would be the police. He knew that all this information would make Max desperate and restless. As a result, Max would take a wrong decision and lose his life.

QUESTIONS

- 8.** In this story, Ausable shows great 'presence of mind', or the ability to think quickly and act calmly and wisely, in a situation of danger and surprise. Give examples from your own experience, or narrate a story, which shows someone's presence of mind.

Ans. In the story 'The Midnight Visitor', Ausable shows great presence of mind or the ability to think quickly and act calmly and wisely in a situation or danger.

Such a similar presence of mind is shown by Gerrard in the story/play 'If I Were You'. When Gerrard is held hostage by a criminal, he not only treats him as a guest but also traps him with his confidence.

Gerrard convinces the criminal that he is also a criminal. He tells him to run away through the exit door which is actually a cupboard. The criminal believes Gerrard and gets trapped in the cupboard while Gerrard calls the police. Thus, it is his presence of mind that helps him get out of a difficult situation.

QUESTIONS

9. "_____ did not fit any description of a secret agent."
- (a) Fowler
 - (b) Max
 - (c) Ausable ✓
 - (d) Henry

QUESTIONS

Ans. (c) Ausable

QUESTIONS

10. Why does Ausable refer to Fowler as 'my young friend'?

- (a) To make a sarcastic comment about Fowler's childishness ~~X~~
- (b) To remind Fowler that young people are usually cheerful ~~X~~
- (c) To reassure Fowler that they are indeed friends ~~X~~
- (d) To highlight how naive and innocent Fowler is ✓✓

QUESTIONS

Ans. (d) To highlight how naive and innocent Fowler is

QUESTIONS

11. What was Fowler's 'first thrill of the day'?

- (a) Meeting Ausable. ✗
- (b) Sight of a man with automatic pistol. ✓
- (c) Seeing a very important paper. ✗
- (d) None of the above. ✗

QUESTIONS

Ans. (b) Sight of a man with automatic pistol.

QUESTIONS

12. How did Fowler feel at the end of the story?

- (a)** Disappointed
- (b)** Thrilled ✓
- (c)** Sad
- (d)** Unhappy

QUESTIONS

Ans. (b) Thrilled

QUESTIONS

13. What is the theme of the story 'The Midnight Visitor'?

(a) Wisdom is more powerful than any weapon.

(b) Never judge a person by his appearance.

(c) First impressions could be misleading.

(d) He who laughs last, laughs longest.

QUESTIONS

Ans. (a) Wisdom is more powerful than any weapon.



QUESTIONS

H/W-2

14. Read the following extract carefully and answer the questions that follow.

Ausable did not fit any description of a secret agent, Fowler had ever read. Following him down the musty corridor of the gloomy French hotel where Ausable had a room, Fowler felt let down. It was a small room, on the sixth and top floor, and scarcely a setting for a romantic adventure.

Ausable was, for one thing, fat. Very fat. And then there was his accent. Though he spoke French and German passably, he had never altogether lost the American accent he had brought to Paris from Boston twenty years ago. "You are disappointed" Ausable said wheezily over his shoulder. "You were told that I was a secret agent, a spy, dealing in espionage and danger. You wished to meet me because you are a writer, young and romantic. You envisioned mysterious figures in the night, the crack of pistols, drugs in the wine."

QUESTIONS

- i.** Which of these describes how Fowler felt at the beginning of the extract?
- (a)** His heart sank.
 - (b)** He was shaken up.
 - (c)** His stomach was in knots.
 - (d)** He was at the end of his rope.

QUESTIONS

Ans. (a) His heart sank.

QUESTIONS

- ii. State one observation about Ausable based on the way he handled Fowler's disappointment with him

Ans. Ausable's reaction on seeing Fowler's disappointment shows that he was perceptive and observant as he noticed Fowler's disappointment as well as the cause of it. Moreover, Ausable was confident. He didn't feel the need to apologise for disappointing Fowler. He accepted his disappointment without judgement. He was experienced enough in his field to understand that the reality of being a spy differs from, the perceptions of it.

QUESTIONS

iii. How did the atmosphere of the French hotel influence Fowler's mood?
Answer in 40 words.

Ans. The French hotel is described as 'gloomy, 'musty' and 'small'. This sombre atmosphere of the hotel added to Fowler's feeling of disappointment. He expected a grand atmosphere of mystery and danger, and was disappointed by the reality of the situation.

QUESTIONS

iv. Which of these means the same as 'romantic' in the line below?

It was a small room, on the sixth and top floor, and scarcely a setting for a romantic adventure.

- (a)** great
- (b)** exciting
- (c)** idealistic
- (d)** passionate

QUESTIONS

Ans. (b) exciting

QUESTIONS

15. Read the following extract carefully and answer the questions that follow.

"Instead, you have spent a dull evening in a French music hall with a sloppy fat man who, instead of having messages slipped into his hand by dark-eyed beauties, gets only a prosaic telephone call making an appointment in his room. You have been bored!". The fat man chuckled to himself as he unlocked the door of his room and stood aside to let his frustrated guest enter. "You are disillusioned," Ausable told him. "But take cheer, my young friend. Presently you will see a paper, a quite important paper for which several men and women have risked their lives, come to me. Some day soon that paper may well affect the course of history. In that thought is in drama, is there not?"

QUESTIONS

- i.** Which of these describes what Ausable is doing in the extract?
- (a)** He is relating to Fowler and attempting to change his view.
 - (b)** He is justifying his appearance to Fowler as that of a real spy.
 - (c)** He is summarising events to help Fowler make sense of them.
 - (d)** He is shaming himself so that Fowler's disappointment reduces.

QUESTIONS

Ans. (d) He is shaming himself so that Fowler's disappointment reduces.

QUESTIONS

ii. What does being disillusioned mean?

Ans. Being disillusioned means to be disappointed at something being different from what one had expected it to be.

QUESTIONS

- iii.** According to the extract, which elements are expected to be present in the life of a spy?
- (a)** Attractive women who deliver information.
 - (b)** Discreet phone calls from other famous spies.
 - (c)** Dramatic events that involve guns and action.
 - (d)** An athletic body that moves in an agile manner.

QUESTIONS

Ans. According to the passage, the elements mentioned in a, c and d are to be present in the life of a spy.

QUESTIONS

iv. Which phrase would correctly substitute 'a chance', in the given sentence from the extract.

But take cheer my young friend.

Ans. Be happy or not be disappointed

QUESTIONS

16. 'Stereotypes are often misleading'. Elaborate on the given quote in the context of 'The Midnight Visitor'.

Ans. It is true that stereotypes are often misleading. When Fowler came to meet Ausable, he had expected a smart looking active man who would deal with pistols, wine and dark eyed beauties. However, the reality was far from it. Ausable was a fat and sloppy man with an accent.

QUESTIONS

17. What could be a reason for Fowler to visit Ausable in 'The Midnight Visitor'?

Ans. Fowler was a writer who wanted to meet Ausable, a secret agent, most probably to get material for his writings. He wanted to know how Ausable tackled different dangerous situations.

Yes, his meeting with Ausable is successful as he comes across a dangerous situation when Max, another secret agent came to take an important document from Ausable.

QUESTIONS

18. Why did Ausable frame the story of the balcony?

Ans. Ausable framed the story of the balcony to save himself and Fowler from the rival secret agent, Max. The rival would have been able to get the important report about the new missiles if Ausable had not created this story.

QUESTIONS

19. Why did Max's face turn black with anger? What did he want Ausable to do?

Ans. Max's face turned black with anger because he felt that his plan of extracting the important document from Ausable was in danger. He knew his plan could fail due to the knocking on the door, which Ausable identified as the police. He wanted Ausable to send the police away.

QUESTIONS

20. How did Ausable get rid of Max without using a weapon?

Ans. Ausable used his quick thinking, wit and creativity to get rid of Max. When he found Max waiting for him in his room, he made a story of a balcony under his window. He convinced Max about the balcony. Thus, when someone knocked at the door, Max fearing it to be the police, jumped out of the window and died.

QUESTIONS

21. Who actually had knocked at the door of Ausable's room? Why did he come there?

Ans. The waiter (Henry) in the hotel where Ausable stayed knocked at the door of Ausable's room. He had brought the drinks which Ausable had ordered when Fowler arrived at the hotel.

He came there because he was doing his duty of serving a customer of his hotel.

QUESTIONS

22. Describe Max as a secret agent.

Ans. Max was a secret agent and an enemy of Ausable. He was thin but not very tall. He appeared clever and cunning like a fox. (Fowler comes across him in Ausable's room when he saw Max. Max had come to take the important report about new missiles. However, he is deceived by Ausable who made him jump out of his window.)

QUESTIONS

23. "Ausable shows great presence of mind in a situation of danger and surprise." Do you agree with this statement? If yes, why?

Ans. Yes, I agree with this statement. Ausable showed great presence of mind when Max pointed a gun at him as he entered the hotel room with Fowler. He remained calm and cool and started inventing stories as required to fool Max into jumping to his death.

QUESTIONS

24. State one likely reason the writer of 'The Midnight Visitor' chose to characterise Ausable as short and fat.

Ans. The writer of 'The Midnight Visitor' chose to characterise Ausable as short and fat because the writer wanted to draw the readers' attention to his wittiness and strong mental ability. He wanted the readers to realise that intelligence did not need an attractive physical appearance.

QUESTIONS

25. The various elements of Robert Arthur's writing style work together to create a sense of tension, uncertainty and suspense, well-suited to the mystery and suspense genre of the story, 'The Midnight Visitor'. Comment, with reference to any one element.

Ans. The author employs various elements of writing style to create a sense of tension, uncertainty, and suspense, well-suited to the story's mystery and suspense genre. The conversation between Ausable and Max is filled with half-truths which heightens the story's sense of mystery.

The reader is left wondering about Max's true motives and intentions, which adds to the sense of uncertainty and tension in the story. Further, the author carefully builds the tension throughout the story, gradually revealing new information and plot twists that keep the reader guessing and on edge.

QUESTIONS

26. What information did Ausable give about the Imaginary balcony? Why did he do so?

Ans. Ausable gave a detailed description of the imaginary balcony located near the window of his room. He told Fowler and indirectly Max that his room was a part of a bigger and larger unit. His room was connected to the next room which had a balcony that extended to the window.

He added that it was the second time when someone had entered his room secretly through the balcony. The hotel management staff had done nothing to block the balcony.

The purpose of discussing these details about an imaginary balcony was to convince his enemy, Max of its existence. He knew that the drink that he had ordered would soon be coming and may prompt Max to jump into the balcony and it happened exactly in the same way As soon as there was a knock at the door, Max was fooled into believing it to be the police. In a hurry to hide, Max jumped into the balcony and this led to his death.

QUESTIONS

27. Ausable was a clever secret agent. Do you agree with the statement? Justify your answer.

Ans. Yes, I agree with the statement that Ausable was a clever secret agent. Initially when Fowler met him, Ausable did not look at all like a conventional secret agent. He was fat and had an American accent. He was unlike the usual secret agents. However, just like spies and secret agents he was very sharp and active. He saved himself as well as Fowler from a dangerous situation by using his intelligence. He cleverly created two stories, one about the balcony outside the window of his room and the other about calling the police for extra protection. *3. Waiter — instruction to bring drinks to his room.* In the face of eminent danger, he remained calm and composed. His composure also saved the important documents from going into the wrong hands of Max. Ausable's intelligence fooled Max into believing a false story and made him jump out of the window. His presence of mind, tactfulness and calmness, all point towards his cleverness and wisdom.

QUESTIONS

28. Why did Max scream shrilly when he dropped to the balcony?

Ans. In the story, 'The Midnight Visitor', Max screamed shrilly when he dropped to the balcony because the balcony did not exist at all. It was just a piece of Ausable's imagination. Ausable had created the story of the balcony to save himself, Fowler and the important papers from reaching to wrong hands. He befooled Max into believing that his balcony exists. His brief description to his guest Fowler regarding the presence of the balcony and his complaints regarding the hotel management convinced Max into believing that there was a balcony just outside the window of Ausable's room. Therefore, when Ausable creates another story of the police, Max tried to jump onto the non-existent balcony without looking. As the room was on sixth floor, Max fell from it unexpectedly and must have died by falling from such a height. His scream was then a result of this unexpected fall.

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